

the longest in Asia. Dating of sediments in Clearwater Cave shows that the caves have evolved over a period of 2 million years. The surrounding landscape has many other features of a limestone karst environment, including deep canyons, underground rivers, and limestone pinnacles. Gunung Mulu is home to millions of bats and cave swiftlets.

Other rivers and lakes in Asia

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Australia and New Zealand

Koonalda Caves

Location The Nullarbor Plain, South Australia

The main significance of this cave in the Nullarbor Plain, a vast area of limestone, is its Aboriginal art. A sinkhole 100 ft (30m) deep leads through relatively soft limestone to a steep passage that connects to a large chamber with a domed roof 150 ft (45m) above the floor. Two more passages lead off from the chamber, one connecting to three underground lakes. The wall art, which is more than 20,000 years old, consists of concentric circles, parallel lines,



▲ LAKE EYRE, COLORED RED BY BACTERIA

and herringbone patterns. In the first chamber, archaeologists have found plenty of evidence that flint mining was practiced here 24,000–14,000 years ago. Hearths and charcoal were presumably used to provide firelight by which to work.

Lake Eyre

Location The Great Artesian Basin, South Australia

When it is full, this endorheic lake covers at least 3,670 square miles (9,500 square km) of the Great Artesian Basin. Most of its water comes from monsoon rains falling on Queensland, in the northeast part of the basin, and entering the lake via the Diamantina River and Coopers Creek. On average, a small flood occurs once every three years, but Lake Eyre fills completely much more rarely.

Occasionally, such as in 1984 and 1989, local rainfall topped up the lake. Now officially known as Kati Thanda-Lake Eyre, it also has the lowest point in Australia— 50 ft (15m) below sea level.

Waituna Lagoon

Location The South coast of South Island, New Zealand

Important as a feeding area for a range of breeding and migratory waterbirds, especially shorebirds, Waituna Lagoon is a freshwater lake pooled behind a coastal gravel barrier. The lake covers an area of 14 square miles (36 square km) and is fed by three streams. It lies over gravel deposited by glacial meltwater during the last ice age and is bordered on its landward side by saltmarsh and bogs. The wide coastal barrier was created by longshore drift.

Huka Falls

Location Waikato River, North Island, New Zealand

This series of waterfalls is on New Zealand's longest river, the Waikato, which drains Lake Taupo. Just upstream of the falls, the river narrows from 330 ft (100m) wide to just 65 ft (20m) as it passes through a canyon that has been incised into hard volcanic rock. The effect of this narrowing, and a rapid descent over a series of small falls, is to accelerate the water as it approaches the final 36-ft (11-m) drop. Consequently, the water thunders over the falls with immense power.

Other rivers and lakes in Australia and New Zealand

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